

Essay Outline #1

Introduction:

Major technological revolutions transform society for the better and worse in communication, work, and economics

- The 19th Century Market Revolution
- The late 20th Century Internet Revolution
- Thesis: Both the Market Revolution and the Internet Revolution accelerated communication and labor productivity as they transformed daily life, but each era also created new conflicts and problems that were unavoidable due to the success of the newly found technologies

Historical Background: The Market Revolution

- Led to canals, steamboats, and railroads → connected different areas and gave faster transportation.
- The telegraph → communication through almost instantaneous messaging.
- Factory labor reshaped working conditions and created wage labor.
- Reform movements resulted from social change → temperance, abolition, and women's rights.
- *Religion and Reform* → reformers believed that society could be changed for the better through moral and social change.

Modern Background: The Internet Revolution (Late 20th Century)

- Personal Computers (PCs), the World Wide Web (WWW), and mobile devices transformed communication.
- *Tech Business News* → Internet “revolutionized communication by enabling instant global connectivity,”
- Economy expanded to digital marketplaces / created new jobs
- Remote work and digital entrepreneurship became new labor/jobs
- *Tech Business News* → Social Effects → increased connectivity and new concerns about privacy (and a need for cybersecurity)

Similarities Between the Revolutions

- Acceleration of communication → messaging
- Expansion of economy/markets → connected markets into a national market / online marketplace
- Created new jobs/industries → Factories / agriculture | software / e-commerce
- Social conflict → Reform Movements | Invasions of privacy, misinformation, conditions
- Winners / Losers → Capitalists gained wealth off of worker's harsh conditions | Technology companies became powerful while some communities were left behind.

Differences Between the Revolutions

- Physical vs. Digital → Physical goods vs. information
- Labor → manual work / factories vs. global / online markets
- Speed of revolution → 19th century took decades | Digital revolution is fast with constant updates

- Inequality: Factory owners vs. workers | Technology monopolies and data control vs. unequal access to internet / power

Conclusion

- Both reshaped the communication, work, and economy of the U.S.
- Internet Revolution shares some of the same patterns and consequences as the Market Revolution
- As technology evolves, Americans face challenges related to inequality, need to adapt, and quick change

Essay #1

Technology's Impact on Society - Jared Lomeli

Major technological revolutions in any time period transform the way people communicate, work, and how the economy fluctuates. The 19th-century Market Revolution and the 20th-century Internet Revolution are both significant moments in U.S. history that accelerated the growth of our daily lives. Both revolutions created opportunities for both employees and employers while also creating greater inequalities and conflicts in those markets. Both the Market Revolution and the Internet Revolution increased communication and productivity as they altered our daily lives, but each period in time also created equally impactful inequalities and conflicts that were unavoidable due to the success.

Historical Background: The Market Revolution

The Market Revolution reshaped the United States by connecting regions through widespread communication and accelerating labor productivity. This period led to new transportation systems, including steamboats and railroads, which linked communities together and allowed for faster and cheaper trade. These inventions created a market where all different occupations could participate in economic activities on a scale that had never existed.

Communication was also drastically changed due to this revolution. The invention of the telegraph allowed messages to be sent across long distances and read instantly. This made business more efficient and helped expand trade across the nation. At the same time, factory labor began to skyrocket. People began to work in assembly

lines within factories rather than producing goods in their homes. Workers in factories had strict schedules and harsh conditions, but still came to work and increased productivity due to the new system's effectiveness. As my class notes from the Benevolent Empire explain, these individuals relied on working long hours as a means of living due to the low wages.¹ Inequalities attached to this new labor system included exploitation, long hours, and low wages.

Major reform movements arose from these issues in the job market, as Americans were concerned about instability and moral decline. These issues mainly came from temperance, abolition, and women's rights. As *American Yawp* states, reformers believed that society could be a "perfect society by eliminating sin and encouraging moral behavior."² They believed in "a conviction that human society could be changed to look more heavenly."³ The Market Revolution reshaped not only the economy and labor productivity, but also the expected values, morals, and reforms during the era.

Modern Background: The Internet Revolution

The Internet Revolution of the late 20th century altered the labor force and how common people communicate in ways that even the Industrial Revolution didn't do. The introduction and rise of PCs (personal computers), the WWW (World Wide Web), and

¹ Jared Lomeli, "Benevolent Empire", class notes, Hist 15

² Joseph Locke and Ben Wright, eds., *The American Yawp*, "Religion and Reform," accessed February 25, 2026, <https://www.americanyawp.com/text/10-religion-and-reform/>.

³ Locke and Wright, *American Yawp*.

mobile devices created an entire market and environment within electronics. According to *Tech Business News*, the internet “revolutionized communication by enabling instant global connectivity,”⁴ allowing people to communicate and send data around the world in seconds. Tech Business News also notes that the internet “connects people from all over the world and allows for a global conversation.”⁵ This shifted American culture and how businesses operated.

The economy also expanded to the digital world during this time as companies were now able to buy and sell as well as promote and advertise online. New industries such as e-commerce and online marketing created job opportunities for many skilled individuals. According to Tech Business News, the internet “has rewritten many rules of engagement”⁶ in business and made “new ways of thinking and connecting.”⁷ In addition, the need for software developers and cybersecurity experts created a job market like nothing before. Remote work has also increased in popularity due to the convenience and ability to complete the desired work. Digital entrepreneurs also began to sprout, giving people a better chance than ever to run their own businesses without needing physical stores or large amounts of supply and capital.

However, while these advancements were incredible for the economy and social aspects of the American population, the increased connectivity raised concerns around

⁴ Tech Business News, “Impact of the Internet on Modern Society,” accessed February 25, 2026, <https://www.techbusinessnews.com.au/blog/impact-of-the-internet-on-modern-society/>.

⁵ Tech Business News, “Impact of the Internet.”

⁶ Tech Business News, “Impact of the Internet.”

⁷ Tech Business News, “Impact of the Internet.”

the privacy of data and the spread of misinformation. We are warned by Tech Business News that “the interconnected nature of the internet has brought about new challenges in terms of cybersecurity.”⁸ The article further explains that “cybersecurity has become a critical concern as cyber threats continue to evolve.”⁹ This once again made cybersecurity a necessity as technology created vulnerabilities in every opportunity it opened. Some vulnerabilities also come with inequalities between those who have access to the internet and those who do not know how to use it. We can see that “digital divides are increasing and could spread across nations,”¹⁰ emphasizing how unequal access to information creates new disadvantages.

Similarities Between the Revolutions

Although these events were more than a hundred years apart, the Market Revolution and Internet Revolution both share many similarities. Both accelerated the economy at tremendous rates. The telegraph of the Market Revolution allowed for the first near-instantaneous messaging system to travel around the world. The Internet Revolution took this many steps further in making global communication immediate and accessible to everyone. Each era led to faster communication, politics, and social life while also altering the way businesses operated.

Both revolutions expanded the global markets and created new economic opportunities. The Market Revolution connected regions and created national trade through the addition of canals and railroads, while the Internet Revolution expanded

⁸ Tech Business News, “Impact of the Internet.”

⁹ Tech Business News, “Impact of the Internet.”

¹⁰ Tech Business News, “Impact of the Internet.”

markets to the online space that connected buyers and sellers worldwide. Both periods saw the development of new industries, such as factories and software development, respectively.

Rapid changes in the world bring social conflict. This was seen with the mass reform movements that came from the Market Revolution, such as temperance, abolition, and women's rights, as Americans believed that the inequalities formed from the accelerated technology could be avoided with the correct leadership and changes. Similarly, the Internet Revolution brought privacy concerns, the spread of misinformation, and the power of monopoly companies online. In both cases, technological advancement created winners and losers who both react very differently. The losers of the Industrial Revolution didn't have access to social services, insurance, or compensation during this time.¹¹ Capitalists and major technological companies were the winners of their respective eras as they gained huge influence over the market, while the factory owners and entry-level workers, respectively, are now facing the consequences of harsher conditions or not being needed at their companies of work.

Differences Between the Revolutions

Now you may believe that the two revolutions seem very similar in their patterns and impact, but they differ in important ways that make them unique. The Market Revolution dealt with physical goods such as crops, textiles, and manufactured goods that still required labor and workers to produce them. The Internet Revolution centered

¹¹ Jared Lomeli, "2nd Great Awakening Notes", class notes, Hist 15

around digital information, which shifted the workforce significantly from factories and labor systems to global online markets, remote work, and digital entrepreneurship.

The speed of the changes was also dramatically different. The Market Revolution took several decades to unfold, as building regional transportation systems is a time-consuming process. The Internet Revolution moved at a much faster pace, with constant changes and upgraded platforms. Inequality also differed between the two revolutions. In the 19th century, inequality existed between factory owners and wage workers, who were often taken advantage of. Today, the inequality stands between the internet's accessibility, control over data, and the monopolies that are forming around large tech companies.

Conclusion

Both the Market Revolution and the Internet Revolution reshaped the communication, economy, and social aspects of the United States at a rate that had never been seen before. The Internet Revolution mirrors many of the same patterns found in the Market Revolution, including expanded markets, inequalities, and social tensions. As technology continues to advance, the need for workforce adaptation is higher than ever before. These revolutions show that technological advancements bring both opportunities for the winners and conflict for the losers of the era, creating a society that is both productive and unpredictable.